



Class Notes

Art of Biblical Words

Reading Skills

Dr. Tim Mackie

Many key biblical words are either unfamiliar or have lost their original meaning in our modern context. Gain the skills you need to understand these words every time you read, and try out some of the best free tools our scholars use to uncover the original meaning of biblical words.

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Module 1: Studying Biblical Words

SESSIONS 1-5

Develop skills for studying biblical words, and explore the role words play in how authors communicate meaning.

Session 1: The Wonderful World of Words

Key Takeaways

- Even unfamiliar words can help convey meaning, but overly familiar words can potentially obscure meaning.
- Meaning has an important relationship to words, but there are more factors for communicating meaning than just words.
- Our modern definitions for words may not match the range of meaning for biblical words written thousands of years ago. Learning to study biblical words is crucial to deepening Bible study.

Finding Meaning in Unfamiliar Words

Jabberwocky

'Twas brillig, and the slithy toves
Did gyre and gimble in the wabe:
All mimsy were the borogoves,
And the mome raths outgrabe.

"Beware the Jabberwock, my son!
The jaws that bite, the claws that catch!
Beware the Jubjub bird, and shun
The frumious Bandersnatch!"

He took his vorpal sword in hand;
Long time the manxome foe he sought—
So rested he by the Tumtum tree
And stood awhile in thought.

And, as in uffish thought he stood,
The Jabberwock, with eyes of flame,
Came whiffing through the tulgey wood,
And burbled as it came!

One, two! One, two! And through and through
The vorpal blade went snicker-snack!
He left it dead, and with its head
He went galumphing back.

"And hast thou slain the Jabberwock?
Come to my arms, my beamish boy!
O frabjous day! Callooh! Callay!"
He chortled in his joy.

'Twas brillig, and the slithy toves
Did gyre and gimble in the wabe:
All mimsy were the borogoves,
And the mome raths outgrabe.

Carroll, Lewis (1871). "Jabberwocky." [*Through the Looking Glass and What Alice Found There*](#). Evertype.

Did you understand what was meant by some of the unfamiliar words in that poem? Why or how is this possible?

Human communication is one of the most amazing and complex activities we participate in every day, even though we rarely think much about it. In this famous poem, Carroll illustrates the complex role that words play in our communication. Although individual words are important for communicating our thoughts, there are many more factors at play. The situational context, the topic at hand, our tone of voice, pace and volume, the "feel" of the paragraph—these all work together to determine meaning.

"Jabberwocky" is a brilliant example of how much can be communicated in the absence of precise words. But it works both ways. [Genesis 1](#) is an example of how little can be communicated even when using very common words.

Losing Meaning in Overfamiliar Words

Genesis 1:1-8 NASB

¹ In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. ² The earth was formless and void, and darkness was over the surface of the deep, and the Spirit of God was moving over the surface of the waters. ³ Then God said, "Let there be light"; and there was light.

⁴ God saw that the light was good; and God separated the light from the darkness. ⁵ God called the light day, and the darkness he called night. And there was evening and there was morning, one day.

⁶ Then God said, "Let there be an expanse in the midst of the waters, and let it separate the waters from the waters." ⁷ God made the expanse, and separated the waters which were below the expanse from the waters which were above the expanse; and it was so. ⁸ God called the expanse "heavens." And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

Even though these English words are fairly common, some are not, and others are being used in ways that are different from how we use them in standard English.

Heavens

The dictionary definition of the English word "heaven" illustrates the different ways we use this word ([dictionary.com](https://www.dictionary.com)).

1. The abode of God, the angels, and the spirits of the righteous after death; the place or state of existence of the blessed after the mortal life.
2. (Initial capital letter) Often Heavens. The celestial powers; God.
3. A metonym for God: May heaven help us!
4. Heavens, (used with a singular verb) a wooden roof or canopy over the outer stage of an Elizabethan theater.
5. Usually heavens. The sky, firmament, or expanse of space surrounding the earth.
6. A place or state of supreme happiness: She made his life a heaven on earth.

The meaning of the word “heaven” in English translations of [Genesis 1:1](#) does not correspond to the most common meaning of the English word (the first definition from [dictionary.com](#)). Rather, the fifth definition is the closest to the word’s meaning in this Bible passage!

To avoid confusion, we have “skies,” a perfectly normal alternative English word for “heaven.”

Earth = The Globe

For modern English readers, the word "earth" most commonly means the planet on which we live, but Hebrew is an ancient Semitic language, and this text was written thousands of years ago. The English word “land” better corresponds to the Hebrew word translated as “earth.”

Formless and Void

What does it mean to say that the “earth” is formless? Doesn’t the English word “earth” mean “the planet,” which exists in the “form” of a sphere, by definition? This sentence makes no sense in modern English! But when we take the time to understand the worldview of the ancient authors, we’ll discover rich meaning in this phrase that will bring greater context to all of Genesis 1.

Expanse

In English, “expanse” refers to a large space that exists between two things, usually horizontally. What does it mean to say that an “expanse” divides waters from waters? We need more than our English word to understand what was in the minds of the biblical author and original audience when they thought of this “expanse.”

Reflection Question

What ideas or images come to mind when you hear the words “heavens” or “earth”?

Session 2: The Encyclopedia Approach to Words

Key Takeaways

- Reading the Bible is a cross-cultural experience.
- When an author sits down to write, they don't use a mental dictionary, they use a mental encyclopedia.
- We must strive to be aware of our own encyclopedia, and guard against imposing our own assumptions and meaning onto the text.
- Reading well requires that we work to discover the encyclopedia of the biblical authors by investigating the historical, cultural, and textual background of the Bible.

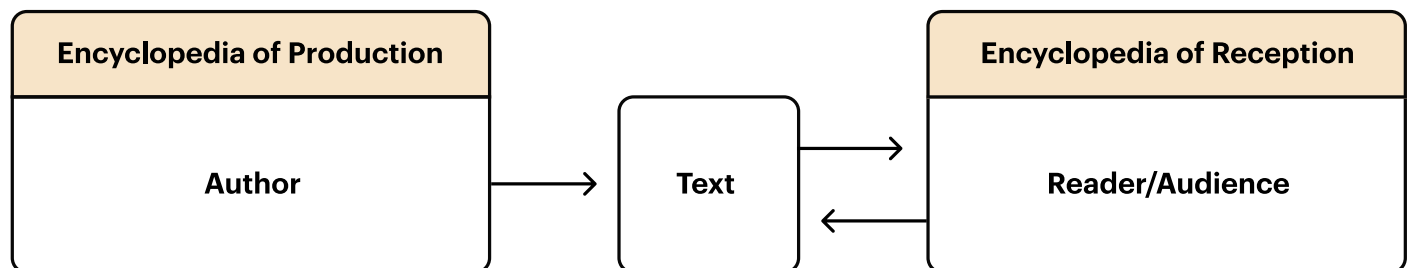
The Dictionary Approach to Words vs. the Encyclopedia Approach to Words

As we read the Bible, we must constantly remind ourselves that we are reading a translation of a text written in a language and culture vastly different from our own. The meaning of these words in English does not help us understand what they mean to the biblical authors.

"Effective communication requires a body of agreed-upon words, terms, and ideas, a common ground of understanding. For the speaker this often requires accommodation to the audience by using words and ideas they will understand. For the audience, if they are not native to the language and cultural matrix of the speaker, this means reaching common ground may require seeking out additional information or explanation. In other words, the audience has to adapt to a new and unfamiliar culture."

Walton, John (2006). [*Ancient Near Eastern Thought and the Old Testament*](#). Baker Books. 19-20.

Understanding the language of another culture requires much more than using a dictionary that lists the meanings of words. We need to understand the larger cultural ideas that make sense of the words in the first place.



Textual Communication. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Where is meaning located? At first, it's in the mind of an author. But in the case of ancient authors, we no longer have access to their minds apart from the text. The text is the literary embodiment of an author's purposed communication.

Encyclopedia of Production and Encyclopedia of Reception

Our encyclopedia is the mental storehouse of words, ideas, images, and stories that we gather and store in our memories from our first waking moments. Every text we read will be interpreted and understood in light of our current operating encyclopedia. Authors have their encyclopedias from which they produce texts, and readers have encyclopedias they use to process and understand texts (see Stefan Alkier, [Reading the Bible Intertextually](#), 3-21).

The reader who wants to understand an author on their own terms will adapt their encyclopedia of reception by learning about the author's encyclopedia of production.

A Two-Step Challenge in Reading the Bible

Step 1: Awareness of our Modern Context

We need to put in the work to become aware of our own modern encyclopedias of reception that we (unknowingly) impose upon the biblical author. For example, we often impose modern cosmology onto the ancient cosmology of [Genesis 1](#) or attribute later doctrinal ideas/debates to the biblical authors (debates about Calvinism vs. Arminianism, divine sovereignty and human free will, etc.).

Step 2: Discovery of the Author's Context

To study Scripture well, we also need to discover the encyclopedia of production assumed by the authors as they communicate. We can channel our learnings into two categories.

1. Historical and cultural: Learn something about the Hebrew language, ancient Near Eastern worldviews, or ancient Israelite history and culture.
2. Textual: The biblical authors assume a high degree of familiarity with the TaNaK because it was first produced and read within a small community immersed in its textual world. It is a highly hyperlinked set of texts, and its puzzles and ambiguities become more clear after continuous re-reading over a lifetime.

Example: "Heart" in the Bible

We might assume that the associations and meanings of our own word "heart" are the same in the Bible (Heb. *lev/levav* - לב/לבב). And there are some places where that's true.

Exodus 4:14 NASB*

... and [Yahweh] said, "Is there not your brother Aaron the Levite? I know that he speaks fluently. And moreover, behold, he is coming out to meet you; when he sees you, he will be **glad in his heart**."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Samuel 1:8 NASB

Then Elkanah her husband said to her, “Hannah, why do you weep and why do you not eat and why is **your heart sad**? Am I not better to you than ten sons?”

Isaiah 61:1 NASB

The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me, because the LORD has anointed me to bring good news to the afflicted; he has sent me to bind up the **brokenhearted**, to proclaim liberty to captives and freedom to prisoners;

But there are many other passages in the Bible where the word “heart” is used in totally different ways from our conception of the word.

Genesis 17:17 NASB

Then Abraham fell on his face and laughed, and **said in his heart**, “Will a child be born to a man one hundred years old? And will Sarah, who is ninety years old, bear a child?”

Exodus 31:6 NASB*

And behold, I myself have appointed with him Oholiab, the son of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan; and I have placed **skill in the hearts** of all who are **skillful of heart**, so they can make all that I have commanded you:

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Kings 4:29 NASB*

Now God gave Solomon wisdom and very great discernment and **breadth of heart**, like the sand that is on the seashore.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Samuel 9:20 NASB*

As for your donkeys which were lost three days ago, do not **set your heart** on them, for they have been found. And for whom is all that is desirable in Israel? Is it not for you and for all your father’s household?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Notice how “set your heart on” is a common English phrase but with a different meaning.

Daniel 1:8 NASB*

But Daniel **set it upon his heart** that he would not defile himself with the king’s choice food or with the wine which he drank; so he sought permission from the commander of the officials that he might not defile himself.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These examples all show that “heart” in Hebrew is associated as much with “mind/thoughts/purpose” as it is with emotions. That’s because there is no Hebrew word for “brain” and no concept of its role within the body!

The heart does double duty in Hebrew, not because of a dictionary but because of their different conception of human physiology. This is a difference in cultural encyclopedia.

Reflection Question

Have you experienced trying to communicate across cultural differences? Take a minute to reflect on the way your experience and context have shaped your readiness for engaging a text like the Bible, which comes from a time, culture, and language different from our own.

Session 3: The Languages of the Bible

Key Takeaways

- The Bible was written in ancient Hebrew, ancient Aramaic, and Koine Greek.
- Jesus and the New Testament authors were raised with an encyclopedia that came from the Hebrew Bible, often by way of its Greek translation.
- Tracing every occurrence of a word throughout the Bible is a powerful way to better understand the range of meaning for that word.
- Tracing a New Testament word back through its use in the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible can reveal connections the author intended to make.

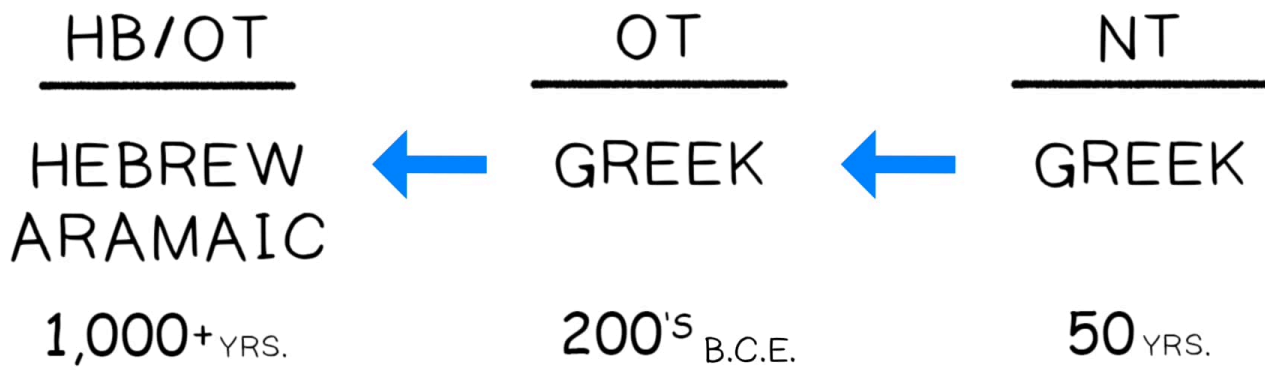
The Languages of the Bible and How to Study Their Vocabulary

The Christian Bible consists of two large literary collections: the Hebrew Bible/Old Testament and the New Testament.

The Bible develops one whole set of ideas in two different languages. If we want to study biblical words, we need to know how to work in two languages.

Languages of the Hebrew Bible/Old Testament	Languages of New Testament
Ancient Hebrew	Koine (“common”) Greek
Ancient Aramaic • Daniel 2:4-7:28 • Ezra 4:8-6:18, 7:11-26 • Jeremiah 10:11	
<i>The Languages of the Bible.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Art of Biblical Words (2021).	

One work bridges these two languages and literary collections. It’s called the Septuagint, and it’s the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible.



Septuagint Bridges Hebrew Bible and New Testament. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Art of Biblical Words (2021).

“Effective communication requires a body of agreed-upon words, terms, and ideas, a common ground of understanding. For the speaker this often requires accommodation to the audience by using words and ideas they will understand. For the audience, if they are not native to the language and cultural matrix of the speaker, this means reaching common ground may require seeking out additional information or explanation. In other words, the audience has to adapt to a new and unfamiliar culture.”

Walton, John (2006). [Ancient Near Eastern Thought and the Old Testament](#). Baker Books. 19-20.

Example 1: “Tent/Dwell” in John 1:14 and Exodus 25:7-8

Hebrew Bible/ Old Testament

Exodus 25:8-9 NASB*

⁸ Let them construct a sanctuary for me, that I may **dwel** (**Heb. *shakhan* / שכן**) among them. ⁹ According to all that I am going to show you, as the pattern of the **tabernacle** (“**tent**” **Heb. *mishkhan* / משכן**) and the pattern of all its furniture, just so you shall construct it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Greek Old Testament/Septuagint

Exodus 25:8-9 LXX/Septuagint*

⁸ And you shall make a sanctuary for me, and I will **become visible** among you. ⁹ And you shall make it for me according to everything I show you on the mountain—the pattern of **the tent (Grk. *skenes* / σκηνης)** and the pattern of all its vessels. So you will make them.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Greek New Testament

John 1:14 NASB*

And the Word became flesh, and **dwelt (Grk. *skenao* / σκηνώ)** among us, and **we saw** his glory, glory as of the only begotten from the Father, full of grace and truth.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In Hebrew, the noun “tent” (*mishkhan*) and the verb “dwell in a tent” (*shakhan*) come from the same root word and are closely connected to the tabernacle, the sacred tent at the center of Israel in the wilderness period.

In the Septuagint, the Greek translators used the common word for “live in a tent” (*skenao*) and “tent” (*skenes*). But the Hebrew Bible’s specific focus on the tent/tabernacle means that the Greek word has been adopted and tweaked to refer specifically to the tabernacle tent.

In the Greek New Testament, John assumes this connection and uses the verb “lived in a tent” in its Hebrew sense. He doesn’t mean that Jesus actually lived in a tent but that he was the divine glory taking on physical form, just as the tabernacle tent was a physical display of the divine presence.

Jesus and the apostles often use Greek words from the Septuagint to activate the encyclopedia of the Hebrew Bible. It’s “Hebrew through Greek.”

Key Takeaway

The apostles often use Greek words, but they activate their Hebrew meaning through the vocabulary of the Septuagint.

When studying New Testament Greek words, we need to be familiar with the Septuagint and look there for the Hebrew correspondents to see the connections in meaning.

Example 2: “Wild and Waste” in Genesis 1:2 and Hebrews 11:3

Hebrew Bible/ Old Testament

Genesis 1:2 Instructor’s Translation

... wild and waste ...

Heb. *tohu va-vohu* / תהו ובהו, meaning unordered and uninhabited

The Greek Old Testament/Septuagint

Genesis 1:2 LXX/Septuagint*

... invisible and unformed ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Grk. *aoratos kai akataskeuastos* / *αόρατος και ακατασκεύαστος*

Greek New Testament

Hebrews 11:3 NASB

By faith we understand that the worlds were prepared by the word of God, so that what is seen was not made out of things which are visible.

Explore Optional Study Tools

Concordances, interlinears, dictionaries, and commentaries are some of the many excellent tools that can help even the most casual student dive deeper into biblical studies.

As we begin to explore these tools, this class will demonstrate the use of Logos Bible software most frequently. We've partnered with the Logos team to craft a starter bundle of resources for Classroom students at a reduced price. [You can check out the bundle on the Logos website](#) or explore other free tools like blueletterbible.org, biblestudytools.com, or netbible.org.

This class was designed to be useful with or without the Logos starter bundle.

Reflection Question

What does it mean to say that the New Testament authors had an "encyclopedia" shaped by the Hebrew Bible?

Session 4: Words and Meanings

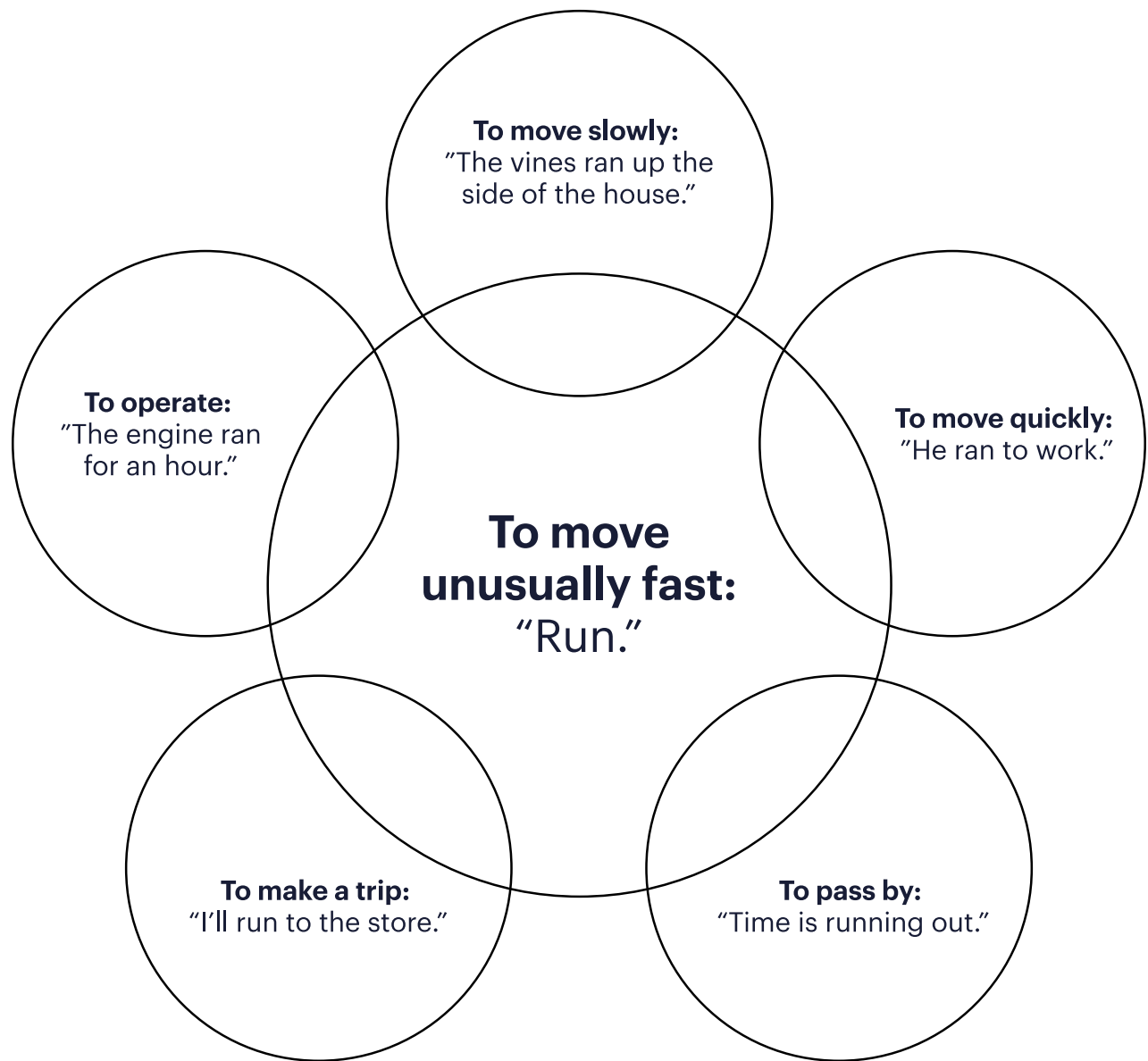
Key Takeaways

- Most words have a range of meanings, and we need context to determine what aspect of a word's meaning an author intends.
- Use a variety of translations when you study. Different translations are like tools designed for different purposes.

Semantic Range

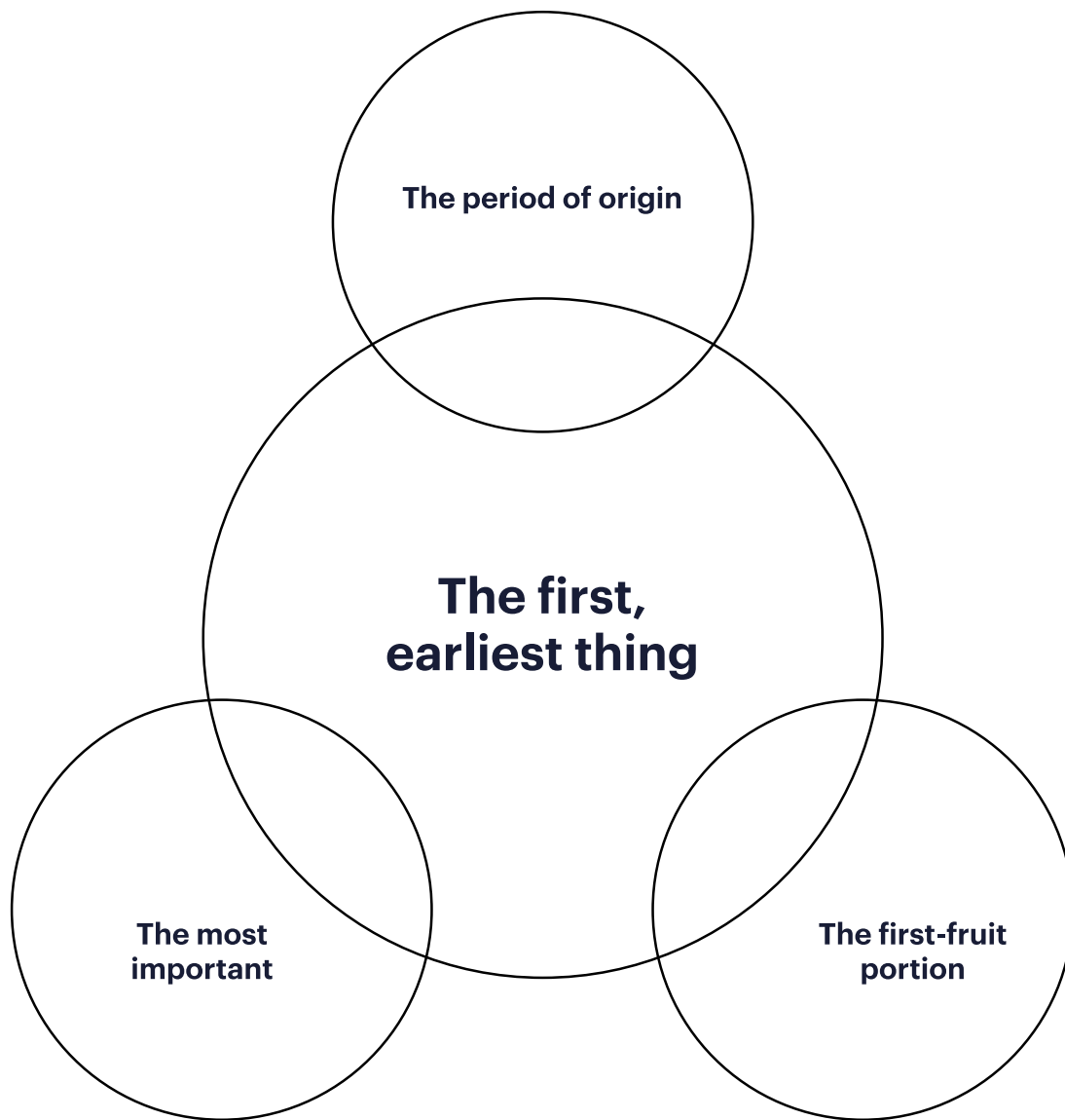
The words we use the most often do not have a specific meaning. Rather, they have a semantic range of meanings that can be activated by different features of the context. In other words, a word itself is only one factor of discovering its meaning.

English Example: Run



Range of Meaning of "Run.". Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Art of Biblical Words (2021).

Hebrew Example: **Raysheet** (ראשית)



Raysheet Range of Meaning. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Art of Biblical Words (2021).

The First, Earliest Thing

Deuteronomy 11:11-12 NIV*

¹¹ But the land you are crossing the Jordan to take possession of is a land of mountains and valleys that drinks rain from heaven. ¹² It is a land the LORD your God cares for; the eyes of the LORD your God are continually on it from the **raysheet** of the year to its end.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Period of Something's Origin

Genesis 10:8, 10 NASB*

⁸ Now Cush became the father of Nimrod; he became a mighty one on the earth ...

¹⁰ The **raysheet** of his kingdom was Babylon and Erech and Accad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Most Important

Amos 6:1 NASB*

Woe to those who are at ease in Zion and to those who feel secure in the mountain of Samaria, the distinguished men of the **raysheet** of nations, to whom the house of Israel comes.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The First-Fruit Portion

Exodus 23:19 NASB*

You shall bring the choice **raysheet** of your soil into the house of the LORD your God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Greek Example: *Pistis* (πίστις)

Ephesians 2:8-9 NIV

⁸ For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God —⁹ not by works, so that no one can boast.

This familiar passage contains so many foundational words in New Testament theology: grace, salvation, and faith versus works.

If we made this passage central to our understanding of faith, it would lead us to conclude that faith is set in opposition to works. If we take this contrast out of its context in Ephesians and in Paul's very nuanced treatment of faith and works of the Torah, this faith/works opposition can lead to a very distorted understanding of faith as belief set in opposition to works.

This is often restated in popular Protestant theology to mean that a person's status as "saved" before God bears no relation to their actions, but only to their correct beliefs. It introduces a dichotomy between belief and behavior that has been very damaging in the history of the Protestant tradition.

What does faith mean in the Greek New Testament? What is the semantic range of this word?

The Act of Trusting in Someone

2 Corinthians 5:6-7 NIV*

⁶ Therefore we are always confident and know that as long as we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord. ⁷ For we live by **pistis**, not by sight.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Peter 1:21 NIV*

Through him you have **pistis** in God, who raised him from the dead and glorified him, and so your **pistis** and hope are in God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These examples show a similar meaning to our English words “believe” or “have faith.” It’s primarily a mental activity—the choice to believe in someone or something.

A Set of Convictions and Beliefs That Define a Social Group

Acts 6:7 NIV*

So the word of God spread. The number of disciples in Jerusalem increased rapidly, and a large number of priests became obedient to the **pistis**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ephesians 4:4-6 NIV*

⁴ There is one body and one Spirit, just as you were called to one hope when you were called;

⁵ one Lord, one **pistis**, one baptism; ⁶ one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These examples show that a social group can be identified with the beliefs or convictions that set it apart from other groups.

Actions That Display a Person’s Trust or Faithfulness

Matthew 9:1-2 NIV*

¹ Jesus stepped into a boat, crossed over and came to his own town. ² Some men brought to him a paralyzed man, lying on a mat. When Jesus saw their **pistis**, he said to the man, “Take heart, son; your sins are forgiven.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Thessalonians 1:3 Instructor’s Translation

We remember before our God and Father
your work that is from **pistis**,
your labor that is from love,
and your endurance that is from hope in our Lord Jesus Christ.

Romans 1:5 NIV*

Through him we received grace and apostleship to call all the Gentiles to the obedience from **pistis** for his name’s sake.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

James 2:14, 17 NIV*

¹⁴ What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have **pistis** but has no works? Can such **pistis** save them? ... ¹⁷ **pistis** by itself, if it is not accompanied by works, is dead.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In each of these texts, *pistis* clearly refers to visible action and behavior, not primarily to a mental activity or choice. In other words, *pistis* can refer to both the choice to believe something and also to the behaviors that result from that belief. They are one and the same.

Paul's Use of the Semantic Range of *Pistis*

Knowing this semantic range helps clarify uses of *pistis* where Paul exploits and combines these different nuances.

Romans 3:21-24 NIV*

²¹ But now apart from the Torah the righteousness of God has been made known, to which the Law and the Prophets testify. ²² This righteousness is through **pistis** of Jesus Messiah for all who show **pistis**. There is no difference between Jew and Gentile, ²³ for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, ²⁴ and all are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that came by Christ Jesus.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Galatians 2:16 NIV*

... know that a person is not justified by the works of the Torah, but through **pistis** of Jesus Messiah. So we, too, have shown **pistis** in Messiah Jesus that we may be justified by **pistis** of Messiah and not by the works of the Torah, because by the works of the law no one will be justified.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Notice how Paul uses the phrase “*pistis* of Jesus” alongside the phrase “showing *pistis* in Jesus” in both passages. Scholars debate whether these are two ways of emphasizing one nuance, the act of trusting in someone, or whether Paul is activating two semantic nuances.

One way to read this as activating two semantic nuances would be to say that because Jesus’ actions displayed *pistis* to God (i.e., the act of trusting in someone), we can now be in right covenant relationship with God if we display an attitude of *pistis* in Jesus (i.e., a set of convictions and beliefs that define a social group).

Reflection Question

Think about a word with a wide range of meanings such as the word “run,” which we use as an example in this session. Are all of its possible meanings intended whenever someone uses the word “run”? Why is this important?

Session 5: Bringing All the Pieces Together

Key Takeaways

- Each biblical author writes with their own emphases, styles, and ideas.
- To better understand how an author is using a word, study it in expanding circles of context—the same book, other works by the same author, the same collection, and the entire Bible.

Semantic Focus

All of us use words in unique ways, which means that using a dictionary and knowing a word's semantic range is not enough. We must actually study the use of a word by a particular author, book, or literary unit to discover the unique nuance of a word in context.

Step One: Study the Semantic Range of Righteousness

Study the following passages to discover the semantic range of the Hebrew words for “righteousness,” *tsedeq/tsedaqah* (צדקה/צדק), and “righteous,” *tsaddiq* (צדיק).

The Actions of a Person Who Does Right by Another Person in the Context of Their Relationship

1 Samuel 12:6-7 NIV*

⁶ Then Samuel said to the people, “It is the LORD who appointed Moses and Aaron and brought your ancestors up out of Egypt. ⁷ Now then, stand here, because I am going to confront you with evidence before the LORD as to all the **tsedaqah** performed by the LORD for you and your ancestors.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 30:33 NIV*

And my **tsedaqah** will testify for me in the future, whenever you check on the wages you have paid me. Any goat in my possession that is not speckled or spotted, or any lamb that is not dark-colored, will be considered stolen.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 38:26 NIV*

Judah recognized them and said, “She has acted with more **tsedaqah** than I, since I wouldn’t give her to my son Shelah.” And he did not sleep with her again.

Ethical Behavior That Aligns With God's Will

Deuteronomy 6:24-25 NIV*

²⁴ The LORD commanded us to obey all these decrees and to fear the LORD our God, so that we might always prosper and be kept alive, as is the case today. ²⁵ And if we are careful to obey all this law before the LORD our God, as he has commanded us, that will be our **tsedaqah**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 106:3 NIV*

Blessed are those who act justly, who always do **tsedaqah**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Proverbs 21:3 NIV*

To do **tsedaqah** and justice is more acceptable to the LORD than sacrifice.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Being in Right Relational Standing With God

Genesis 15:6 NIV*

Abram believed the LORD, and he credited it to him as **tsedaqah**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 53:11 NIV*

After [my servant] has suffered,
he will see the light of life and be satisfied;
by his knowledge my **tsaddiq** servant will make many **tsaddiq**,
and he will bear their iniquities.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Step Two: Learn the Greek Word Used in the Septuagint to Translate the Hebrew Word

Psalms 10:7 LXX/Septuagint*

... because the Lord is *dikaio*s and he loved *dikaio*sune. His face saw uprightness.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Step Three: Study the Semantic Range of *Dikaio*sune

Study the semantic range of the word in the Greek New Testament, paying attention to semantic focus in different authors and books.

Matthew

In Matthew's Gospel, the word "*dikaiosune*" has a semantic focus on behavior that aligns with God's will, especially as revealed in the Torah.

Matthew 1:18-19 NASB

¹⁸ Now the birth of Jesus Christ was as follows: when his mother Mary had been betrothed to Joseph, before they came together she was found to be with child by the Holy Spirit. ¹⁹ And Joseph her husband, being a **righteous man** and not wanting to disgrace her, planned to send her away secretly.

Matthew 3:15 NIV

Jesus replied, "Let it be so now; it is proper for us to do this to fulfill all **righteousness**." Then John consented.

Matthew 5:20 NIV

For I tell you that unless your **righteousness** surpasses that of the Pharisees and the teachers of the law, you will certainly not enter the kingdom of heaven.

Paul

In Paul's letter to the Romans, he uses the *dikaiosune* word group to activate the entire semantic range of the Hebrew words for "righteousness."

Romans 1:17 NIV

For in the gospel the **righteousness** of God is revealed—a **righteousness** that is from faith and results in faithfulness, just as it is written: "The **righteous** will live by faith."

Here righteousness means both God's character of doing right by his covenant promises and a person's right relational status with God.

Romans 6:13 NIV

Do not offer any part of yourself to sin as an instrument of wickedness, but rather offer yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life; and offer every part of yourself to him as an instrument of **righteousness**.

Here righteousness means ethical behavior that aligns with God's will.

Romans 4:23-25 NIV*

²³ The words "it was credited to [Abraham]" were written not for him alone, ²⁴ but also for us, to whom God will credit **righteousness**—for us who believe in him who raised Jesus our Lord from the dead. ²⁵ He was

delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our **justification [= to create our right relational status with God]**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here righteousness means being in right relationship with God.

Paul is aware of the wide semantic range of *dikaiosune*, and he activates those different nuances depending on the contextual point he wants to make. Matthew, on the other hand, uses the same word to consistently activate one nuance of meaning. Knowing the dictionary definition of a word is only one part of understanding what a particular author means. We need to track with the unique ways each author uses words to gain a deeper understanding.

Key Resources for Studying Biblical Vocabulary

For Those With No Knowledge of Greek and Hebrew

- [Lexham Theological Wordbook](#) (digital only in Logos Bible software)

For Those With Knowledge of Greek and Hebrew

- [New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis](#), edited by Willem VanGemeren (print and [digital in Logos](#))
- [New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology and Exegesis](#), edited by Moisés Silva (print and [digital in Logos](#))

The standard English dictionaries of ancient biblical Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek presuppose a knowledge of the languages. All are available in digital or print forms.

- BDB: [A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament, with an Appendix Containing the Biblical Aramaic](#), edited by Francis Brown, Samuel Rolles Driver, and Charles Augustus Briggs (1977). Clarendon Press.
- HALOT: [The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament](#), edited by L. Koehler and Walter Baumgartner (1994). Brill.
- BDAG: [A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature](#), edited by Walter Bauer, F.W. Danker, W.F. Arndt, and F.W. Gingrich (2000). University of Chicago Press.

Helpful Books on Biblical Words and How to Do Word Studies

- Schlimm, Matthew Richard (2018). [70 Hebrew Words Every Christian Should Know](#). Abingdom Press.
- Carson, D.A. (1996). [Exegetical Fallacies](#). Baker Academic.
- Mangum, Douglas and Josh Westbury (2017). [Linguistics and Biblical Exegesis](#). Lexham Press.
- Silva, Moisés (1995). [Biblical Words and Their Meaning: An Introduction to Lexical Semantics](#). Zondervan Academic.

Recommended Habits for Studying Biblical Words

1. Set Your Mindset

We're seeking to understand the biblical authors' encyclopedia of meaning for their word choices. We want to let the context of the Bible paint a picture of the authors' intended meaning and avoid imposing our own assumptions.

2. Choose a Word

To get started, select a word from a verse in the Bible. Try to pick a word that you sense has significance for the understanding of the passage. In class, we use the examples of faith, righteousness, beginning, heart, and dwelt (and its connection to the tabernacle).

3. Compare Multiple Translations

Use a parallel Bible or similar tool (Logos, Bible Gateway) to see how this word was translated in multiple biblical translations. We recommend comparing at least four—NASB, NIV, ESV, and NLT. Note any differences between the translations and begin to sketch out characteristics of the semantic range of the word based on the passage's context.

4. Identify the Original Language Word

You can use an interlinear Bible or similar tool that shows the original language words along with the translation. You may also consider trying the [Bible study tool Logos](#) that Tim uses in class.

5. Look up Definition and Translations

Look up the Greek/Hebrew/Aramaic word with an online tool like [blueletterbible.org](#) or the Word Study feature in Logos Bible software. Note the given definition and all the ways that this word is translated in your Bible translation.

6. Find All Uses of This Word in the Bible

Use a concordance or Bible search tool to identify every place the biblical authors use this word.

- **Uses within the same book:** Focus on the most immediate context and examine the author's use of the word in the same book. Pay attention to nuances and continue sketching out the word's semantic range.
- **Uses by the same author:** Next, look at other occurrences of the word within the same author's other writing. For example, if you start with the word "faith" in Paul's letter to the Ephesians, which is *pistis* in Greek, examine the way Paul uses the word "*pistis*" in his other letters.
- **All uses in the Bible:** Finally, examine all of the other places this word shows up in the Bible. In the example of *pistis* in Ephesians, this step would yield a list of 243 verses in the New Testament.

7. Categorize Occurrences According to Similarity in Semantic Focus

Group verses with similar nuances of meaning together and give those groups short titles or descriptions. Think about the example of the English word “run.” You might create a category having to do with moving very fast (“ran 100m”), a category for things operating or functioning (“production is running smoothly”), and so on.

8. Trace a Greek Word Through the Septuagint to Related Words From the Hebrew Bible

Note: Steps 8 and 9 only apply to New Testament Greek words, so if you are doing a Hebrew/Aramaic word study, skip to step 10.

Use the Word Study feature in Logos (or a similar tool) to find the original Hebrew words that the authors were translating into your chosen Greek word when creating the Septuagint.

- **Make observations about your word study results.** Was this Greek word used by the Septuagint to translate many different Hebrew words or just a handful? Is there one Hebrew word that seems most frequently associated with this Greek word?
- **Identify the most applicable Hebrew word(s).** Look up that word in your word study tool (or Bible dictionary). Does this Hebrew word have a semantic range we need to pay attention to?
- **Trace this Hebrew word to all of its occurrences in the Hebrew Bible.** What did this Hebrew word mean in various contexts in the Hebrew Bible?
- **Build your encyclopedia entry for this word group.** Categorize these occurrences according to their similarities in semantic focus. Group occurrences with a similar nuance of meaning together and give that group a short title or description.

9. Combine Your Results

Observe the range of meaning in the Hebrew word(s), and observe the range of meaning in the occurrences of the Greek word in your passage.

- What kinds of connections does this word have to the larger biblical story?
- What nuances of meaning seem most likely intended by the New Testament author?
- What nuances of meaning can you set aside as unlikely interpretations?

10. Consult Other Scholars

Use a theological wordbook or commentary to gain insights from other peoples’ studies of biblical words.

Reflection Question

Why is it important to consider the uniqueness of an author or book when searching for a word’s meaning?